

Advisory Panel System

Tips for preparing the documents for your AP meeting



A dissertation project covers an extensive period of time and involves continuous work - the prospect of which may be equally exciting and daunting. Advisory Panel will offer guidance and support along the way and careful preparation for meeting will help to focus the discussion on the relevant topics and get the most out of the meetings. The following documents are tools which help you on your way.

Status/Progress Report

- approx. 3-5 pages
- should give an overview of the status of your PhD project, including your research question, what you have done so far, any first results or achievements, your next steps. If you are more advanced in your project, planned publications relating to your thesis can also be mentioned.
- Status reports will allow you to reflect on your work done so far, review your methodology, formulate first conclusions, and help you to identify potential gaps or problems. It is not intended as an exam but rather a tool to facilitate and focus discussion for the AP meeting.
- The format of your report is for you to decide. No matter if it is written text only or includes graphics or charts – keep in mind that it should follow a logical basic structure. If appropriate to your research, why not include the 2-3 most important new graphs showing your latest results?

Thesis Outline

- The outline is the core of your thesis, use major keywords to add substance to the individual chapters and sub-chapters. The thesis should have 2 or 3 main chapters; more are optional. Ideally a chapter can be published as scientific paper in a peer-reviewed journal.
- It is good to think about a possible research outline early in your studies to help you define and shape your project. It will also help you to set the general scope of your project and assess what work you will need to do (e.g. experiments, literature research, etc).
- Don't be disturbed if your outline is not very detailed at the beginning of your studies – this will quickly be remedied as you progress in your research project. Also, keep in mind that sometimes it may be wise to review and modify parts of the outline – seek the advice of your AP.
- Preparing a well-structured thesis outline and a realistic time schedule is not only essential for the timely progress of the PhD research but also an excellent generic skill training, preparing young scientists for future tasks such as the writing of research proposals.

Thesis outline: NAME; DATE (revised: DATE)

THESIS TITLE Abstract

(key sentences placing the main research question/hypothesis in the general context; distinguishing the subordinating scientific questions, mention the expected results/new information for science)

Introduction

(key words: 'state of the art', leading to your overall research question; expected original contribution to the new knowledge in the field)

Main Chapter 1: Title

- 1.1. Introduction (key words: importance of research topic, your specific question and goals)
- 1.2. Material and Methods (include models/codes, data, analysis tools and methods to be applied)
- 1.3. Results (key words: expected results of your study that answer your research question)

Main Chapter 2: Title

(for this and all following chapters structure as above)

Summary

(Key words: 'wrapping' the whole work by reflecting the expected major findings of your study)

References

(Key references you will use for your research)

Table 2: Example for a possible thesis outline

Time Schedule

- The time schedule should cover the entire period of your doctoral studies. As with any project, understanding the tasks ahead of you and the timeframe these require will help you to keep on track of your dissertation project. Important milestones during the PhD programmes should be given as well.
- A graphical presentation of the time windows assigned for individual tasks is extremely effective to evaluate the feasibility of a time plan. It also makes it easier to understand, review and identify extremely busy times.
- Colour coding is a great way to highlight individual periods assigned for specific tasks (e.g. experiments, method development, literature review, writing).
- If known, try to consider any longer planned absences which may affect your thesis work (e.g. extended beam-time slots, conferences, etc.) and integrate them into your graphical presentation.
- Schedule enough time for each task to allow for some flexibility.
- Remember to allocate time for tasks proof-reading, printing etc. in the end phase of your PhD and be aware of any deadlines.

Useful resource

Your Dissertation Plan – 18 Free Tools

<http://www.postgrad.com/blog/your-dissertation-plan/>